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Two-time Olympian, winner of four medals at Commonwealth Games and nine-time Senior National Champion



LET'S BE BULLISH ABOUT OUR OLYMPIC MEDAL ASPIRATIONS!

Looking ahead to 2024, the goal of becoming a **formidable force** in badminton seems achievable.

The evolution of Indian badminton has been both noteworthy and newsworthy over the years. This is reflected in the country's No. 6 position in the latest World Team Rankings. While individual rankings may often take precedence, this comprehensive team ranking takes into account performance across all five events and the three World Team Championships (Sudirman, Thomas, and Uber Cup). Despite a relatively weak performance in the women's singles event in 2023 and mixed doubles still developing, India's overall ranking confirms its growing status as a badminton powerhouse.

Looking ahead to 2024, the goal of becoming a formidable force in badminton seems achievable.

The aim is to build on the success of securing a medal in each of the last three Olympic Games by adopting an aggressive approach to clinch multiple medals, including a coveted gold, at the Paris Olympic Games. Additionally, the target includes securing more than four medals at the Paralympics, successfully defending the Thomas Cup, and also winning individual titles at the biggest World Tour events.

The BWF's Race to Paris Ranking List for Olympic Qualification, based on performances from May 1, 2023, to April 28, 2024, provides insights into potential participation at the Paris Olympics.

Leading the charge for India will be the unstoppable men's doubles duo Satwik Sairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, the Asian Games gold medallists and current world no. 2. With their track record, Olympic qualification is assured. With enough time to prepare for the Olympics, which will be held in the last week of July, using their proven approach of logical incrementalism, fusing strategy and implementation, and carrying the confidence of having beaten every other potential pairing at least once, they stand a realistic chance of claiming the ultimate prize, the

Olympic gold.

In men's singles, the seasoned H.S. Prannoy, ranked world no. 8, adds an air of anticipation for another Olympic medal, having found top form at 31 and securing a historic bronze medal at the recent Asian Games. The quest for a second entry in this category hinges on Lakshya Sen or Kidambi Srikanth breaking into the top 16 rankings. For the women's singles, superstar P.V. Sindhu is expected to come back from her injury break refreshed, recalibrated, and believing that she has it in her to chase down her third Olympic medal.

The race for qualification in women's doubles is tightly contested between pairs Ashwini Ponnappa/Tanisha Crasto and Treesa Jolly/Gayatri Gopi Chand. The outcome remains uncertain, pending the final stretch of the qualification period. The Indian men's team will have to defend their Thomas Cup title this year. They won the tournament for the first time in 2022, beating strong opponents like 14-time champions Indonesia in the final.

However, the proximity of the event to the Olympics will pose a training challenge for top players, who might find it hard to peak at both of these events.

Apart from this, in 2024, it would be good to see emerging Indian talents come to the forefront.

Having established role models with colossal achievements, understandably, the youngsters have big boots to fill. However, they also now have a proven blueprint and support systems to back their belief and hard work, preparing them to navigate both a steep learning curve and achieve consistency in performance.

In conclusion, one would have to admit that in an Olympic year, it is hard to prioritise any other event, so let's be bullish on our Olympic medal aspirations, seeking the brilliant shine of gold, and look to continue the momentum through young talents and a set Indian coaching system to propel Indian badminton to new heights.